

SOB OPERA: Gautami Kapoor plays Tulsi in Star Plus's *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*



◀◀ **SAAS-BAHU SORTIES**

● The 'regressives' started with Star Plus's *Kyunki..* and moved to *Kahaani Ghar Ghar Ki*. The story continues with Zee TV launching *Teen Bahuraniyan* and *Meri Doli Teri Angana*.

● New channels refuse to take another route and while Sahara One recently launched *Mera Sasural*, 9X has churned out *Dahej*.



the reality formats haven't been spared. Not content with poaching Gajendra Singh from Zee TV in 2006, Star Plus also cloned the formats. So if Zee TV had *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Li'l Champs*, Gajendra's clone of his own show *Star Voice of India* had its junior version, *Star Voice of India Chhote Ustad*. Ditto with 9X, which joined the fun and games by launching *Chak De Bachche*—their attempt at finding the next dancing and singing child superstar.

Efforts to launch youth-oriented channels have come unstuck. Take Star One, launched in 2004 as a niche network for the urban youth. It's a fickle audience—the 16 to 34-year-olds. To tap into this audience that has no time for *saas-bahu* and *beti* sagas and invariably turns to music channels, Star One started with a bang with shows like *Remix*, *India Calling*, *Sarabhai vs Sarabhai* and *The Great Indian Comedy Show*. It topped this with the first season of *Nach Baliye*

that started the celebrity dance-drama craze. But *Nach Baliye*'s second season was shifted to Star Plus and *The Great Indian Comedy Show* as well as *Sarabhai vs Sarabhai* ended their first season. So out went shows targeting the urban hip and in came shows aimed at India's top 20 towns, from *Betiyaan—Apna Ya Paraya Dhan*, a soap about the travails of being a daughter, to *Dill Mil Gaye*, a story about inter-personal relationships set against the backdrop of a hospital. The latest casualty in the youth-based space has been Zee TV's younger cousin, Zee Next. The channel currently has a market share of only 0.4 per cent, according to Audience Measurement and Analytics Limited.

"We don't want to do different things. We just want to do things differently," says Shailaja Kejriwal, executive vice-president, content, NDTV Imagine. Yes, if one says that *Ramayan* is Doordarshan redux with

better technology, or *Radha Ki Betiyaan Kuch Kar Dikhayengi* is *Banegi Apni Baat* 10 years later—ironically, the struggle of a mother to bring up multiple daughters in a big town is being churned out by the same team of Deeya and Tony Singh.

In the next one year, at least three new entertainment channels, one each by Viacom18, Reliance and Miditech-Turner, will vie for audience attention. Art Buchwald once said, "Every time you think television has hit its lowest ebb, a new type of programme comes along to make you wonder where you thought the ebb was?" Siddhartha Basu, chairman of Synergy Adlabs, sees hope in the clutter-cutters such as his own forthcoming real (as opposed to reality) show *Aap Ki Kacheri* on Star Plus and the instructional show, *Angrezi Mein Keh-te Hain*, on NDTV Imagine. Will he, and indeed Hindi entertainment channels, prove Mr Buchwald right? ■